Introduction

Towards the Brink

‘One out of three and even’.[1]

(John F. Kennedy’s assessment of the risk of nuclear war in October 1962)

‘The missile crisis was a dramatic demonstration of human fallibility, of the degree to which political and military leaders are so often captive of misinformation, misjudgement, miscalculation. We all make mistakes. In our daily lives, mistakes are costly, but we try to learn from them. In conventional war, mistakes cost lives, sometimes thousands of lives. But if mistakes were to affect decisions relating to nuclear forces, they will result in the destruction of nations.’[2]

(Robert McNamara, US Secretary of Defense)

‘Nothing beats the lessons on decision-making imparted by the accounts of the way in which JFK handled the decisions surrounding the Cuban Missile Crisis – his calmness, his refusal to bow to pressure, whether from within or without, his willingness to contend with imperfect information while being under enormous pressure and relentless press coverage, puts everything else in perspective. Making decisions that send 75,000 people home happy at the end of a Saturday afternoon is one thing. Saving hundreds of millions from a nuclear war is another.’[3]